



Costa Rica



Area 19,730 sq miles
(51,100 sq km)

Population 4.7 million

Capital San José

Currency Costa Rican colón

Official language Spanish

Life expectancy 79 years



◀ RED-EYED TREE FROG

Known for its bulging red eyes, the colorful red-eyed tree frog can be found near ponds, streams, and rivers along Costa Rica's Caribbean coast. This tree frog eats insects that it catches with its long, sticky tongue. Suction cups on its toes allow it to climb trees.

The Republic of Costa Rica is a small country in Central America located near the southern tip of the North American continent. To its east is the Caribbean Sea and to its west is the Pacific Ocean. Costa Rica was ruled by Spain until 1821, gaining full independence in 1838. The population is mostly *mestizo*, of partly Spanish origins, with only about 35,000 indigenous Amerindians. The main language is Spanish, but English Creole is also spoken. Coffee, technology, and tourism are the country's main industries. More than 90 percent of Costa Rica's electricity comes from renewable sources.

Mexico



Area 761,606 sq miles
(1,972,550 sq km)

Population 115 million

Capital Mexico City

Currency Mexican peso

Official language Spanish

Life expectancy 74 years



The most populated Spanish-speaking country in the world, Mexico separates the United States from the rest of Latin America (the countries whose main language is Spanish or Portuguese). Mexico was ruled by the Aztecs until the 16th century, when it became part of the Spanish Empire for nearly 300 years. Greater Mexico City, which

includes the capital and 18 connected districts, is one of the largest metropolitan areas in the world. Mexican national identity is formed of *mestizaje*—a combination of European and indigenous cultures. In addition to Spanish, indigenous languages such as Nahuatl, Mayan, and Tzeltal are also spoken. Despite Mexico being a global oil producer, its exports have dropped in recent years and it now faces great wealth inequality. More than 44 percent of the population live below the national poverty line. Indigenous communities living in the country's rural areas are the most disadvantaged groups.

▼ CHACMOOL, MEXICO CITY

A chacmool is a sculpture of a reclining male figure holding a bowl. Chacmoos were made by Native Americans and have been excavated from sites across central Mexico.

